

Tobacco Liberty

prc-tobacco-liberty

Christian Ethics · Substances · practice · divided_lineages

DISPUTED

Supported across many Bible texts

Reached by general principle, not by a naming word

Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

Tobacco use is a matter of Christian liberty with health-stewardship cautions, not sin per se.

In plain language

Tobacco does not appear anywhere in the Hebrew or Greek Bible, so there is no word to look up and the question has to be answered from broader principles. Two streams of text pull in different directions and the vocabulary does not rank them. Romans 14 builds a real category of disputable matters, what Paul calls 'distinctions of opinions' (diakrisis dialogismon). Paul tells believers that one person eats and another abstains, that each does so before the Lord with thanksgiving, and that neither may despise (exoutheneo) or judge (krino) the other, because God has welcomed (proslambano) them both. Each will finally give account of himself to God. The chapter even says outright that 'nothing is unclean in itself' (ouden koinon di heautou), and the Gospel of Mark records Jesus declaring that what enters the mouth from outside does not defile, with the Evangelist's note that he was 'cleansing all foods' (katharizon panta ta bromata). That pattern fits a substance Scripture never directly forbids and points toward treating it as a matter of conscience. The other stream sets a boundary. In 1 Corinthians 6 the body (soma) is called a sanctuary (naos) of the Holy Spirit, bought with a price (agorazo), so the believer is to glorify God (doxazo) in the body. Just before that, Paul says 'all things are lawful' (panta exestin) but 'not all are beneficial' (ou panta sympherei), and that he will not be mastered (exousiasthesomai) by anything. In 1 Corinthians 10 he repeats the slogan with a community test added, the verb 'builds up' (oikodomei), then says whether we eat or drink we should do all to the glory of God. Romans 14 itself bounds liberty with 'stumbling block' (proskomma) and 'snare' (skandalon) language, telling the strong not to harm the weak. These verses do not name tobacco either, but they raise a genuine question about whether a habit known to harm the body or create dependency can be carried out to God's honor without becoming a snare to others. Because the specific subject is missing from the text and the general principles cut both ways, with freedom of conscience on one side and stewardship plus neighbor-love on the other, the lexical pattern does not settle the matter in one direction. The words establish the framework but leave the concrete verdict on this particular substance contested.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0059	ἀγοράζω	agorazo	to buy	31
G1392	δοξάζω	doxazo	to glorify	62
G1832	ἐξέστιν	exestin	be permitted	31
G1848	ἐξουθενέω	exoutheneo	to reject	11
G2068	ἐσθίω	esthio	to eat	65

G2168	εὐχαριστέω	eucharisteo	to thank	38
G2316	θεός	theos	God	
G2840	κοινώω	koinoo	to profane	14
G2919	κρίνω	krino	to judge	115
G3485	ναός	naos	temple	46
G4348	πρόσκομμα	proskomma	stumbling block	6
G4355	προσλαμβάνω	proslambano	to take	13
G4625	σκάνδαλον	skandalon	stumbling block	15
G4851	συμφέρω	sympherei	be profitable	17
G4983	σῶμα	soma	body	144
G5426	φρονέω	phroneo	to reason	30

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

Tobacco is unknown to the biblical world and is named by no Hebrew or Greek word, so the proposition cannot be settled by a direct word study and must be derived from general categories. Two text-level streams pull in opposite directions and the vocabulary does not rank them. Romans 14 builds a real category of 'distinctions of opinions' (diakrisis dialogismon) in which opposite practices are validated 'before God' (coram Deo) with thanksgiving and mutual judging is forbidden, which is the strongest internal warrant for treating an unforbidden substance as 'indifferent matters' (adiaphora, things neither commanded nor forbidden). Against this, 'sanctuary' (naos) in 1 Corinthians 6:19 with the perfect passive 'you were bought' (egorasthete) and the imperative 'glorify God in the body' (doxasate ton theon en to somati), the 'all things are lawful' (panta exestin) yet 'not all are beneficial' (ou panta sympherei) and 'I will not be mastered' (ouk exousiasthesomai) pair in 1 Corinthians 6:12 and 10:23, and the 'stumbling block' (proskomma) and 'snare' (skandalon) vocabulary of Romans 14:13 to 14:21 impose a real stewardship and brotherly-love qualification. Because the canon supplies the framework but not a verdict on this specific substance, the lexical pattern is materially contested rather than settled.

Scripture

1Cor.6.19 · neutral · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G3485 ναός, G4983 σῶμα

Reasoning. 'Your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit who is in you' (to soma humon naos tou en humin hagiou pneumatou estin), that is, your body is a temple of the indwelling Holy Spirit. 'Sanctuary' (naos) is the inner sanctuary, used 46 times in the canon and overwhelmingly of the temple proper, which lifts the body from neutral matter to consecrated space. The second-person plural 'you know' (oidate) frames this as something believers hold in trust rather than own outright. This grounds a stewardship duty over the body that any liberty claim must accommodate. The verse names no specific substance and so cannot by itself classify tobacco as sin or as permitted.

1Cor.6.20 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0059 ἀγοράζω, G1392 δοξάζω

Reasoning. 'You were bought with a price' (egorasthete gar times) is in the aorist passive (a completed past action in the passive voice) and locates ownership in the buyer rather than the body. 'Therefore glorify God in your body' (doxasate de ton theon en to somati humon) is aorist imperative second-person plural (a completed-action command addressed to a group) and pairs an actor with a sphere of action. Together the warrant and imperative orient bodily conduct toward God's honor and supply the stewardship caution clause of the proposition. The verse does not by lexeme (the actual dictionary word) decide whether a particular use dishonors that trust.

Rom.14.1 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4355 προσλαμβάνω, G2919 κρίνω

Reasoning. 'As for the one who is weak in faith, welcome him, but not to quarrel over opinions' (ton asthenounta te pistei proslambanesthe me eis diakriseis dialogismon), opens a defined category of practices that are not to be tests of fellowship. 'Welcome' (proslambano) in its 13 canon occurrences carries the warm sense of welcoming or taking to oneself, used both of Christ welcoming believers and of believers welcoming each other. 'Distinctions of opinions' (diakrisis dialogismon) is the technical phrase that defines what the chapter governs. This creates the structural slot of a 'disputable matter' (something believers may differ on without sin) into which a substance with no direct prohibition could fall.

Rom.14.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2068 ἐσθίω, G1848 ἐξουθενέω

Reasoning. 'The one who eats must not despise the one who abstains' (ho esthion ton me esthionta me exoutheneito), and 'the one who abstains must not judge the one who eats' (ho me esthion ton esthionta me krineto), because 'God has welcomed him' (ho theos auton proselabeto). The reciprocal third-person imperative (a command issued about a third party) prohibition on contempt and judgment sets practice in this category outside the sin or not-sin binary at the level of mutual standing, which favors a liberty framing while leaving the concrete act unevaluated.

Rom.14.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5426 φρονέω, G2168 εὐχαριστέω

Reasoning. 'The one who eats, eats in honor of the Lord, since he gives thanks to God' (ho esthion kurio esthiei, eucharistei gar to theo), and the abstainer likewise abstains in honor of the Lord and gives thanks. Both opposite practices are validated when done 'before God' (coram Deo) with thanksgiving, which is the strongest internal signal that the category tolerates either choice. The validation is conditioned on Godward orientation through the dative 'to the Lord' (kurio, the noun in the 'to-X' grammatical form) and the thanksgiving clause, not unconditional, so it does not license self-harm.

Rom.14.12 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2316 θεός

Reasoning. 'So then each of us will give an account of himself to God' (ekastos hemon peri heautou logon dosei to theo). The verse closes the disputable-matter unit by locating final adjudication in personal accountability to God rather than communal verdict, which supports liberty in conscience but also preserves a real standard of accountability that a stewardship caution can attach to.

Rom.14.13 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4348 πρόσκομμα, G4625 σκάνδαλον

Reasoning. 'Decide rather never to put a stumbling block or hindrance in the way of a brother' (me titheinai proskomma to adelpho e skandalon), that is, do not place a stumbling block or trap before your brother. 'Stumbling block' (proskomma) occurs only 6 times in the canon and 'snare' (skandalon) 15, and Romans 14 to 15 with 1 Corinthians 8 to 10 are the densest concentration. The liberty granted in Romans 14:1-6 is here explicitly bounded by neighbor-love. The vocabulary makes the boundary part of the liberty teaching, not external to it, which complicates any reading that takes Romans 14 as unqualified permission.

Rom.14.14 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2840 κοινώω

Reasoning. 'Nothing is unclean in itself' (ouden koinon di heautou), with 'unclean' (koinon) as the predicate adjective (the describing word that completes 'X is Y') uses the same word family as Mark 7:18-19 where Jesus declares foods clean. The construction 'of itself' (di heautou) removes intrinsic defilement from material things while preserving conscience as the operative category in the next clause. Applied to a substance the canon never names, the sentence by itself permits a non-prohibition reading, but the verse continues with 'but it is unclean for anyone who thinks it unclean' (ei me to logizomeno ti koinon einai, ekeino koinon), which restores subjective conscience as binding for the one who so reckons.

Mark.7.19 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2840 κοινώω

Reasoning. 'Thus he declared all foods clean' (katharizon panta ta bromata) is the Evangelist's (Gospel writer's) editorial gloss on Jesus' saying that what enters the mouth from outside cannot defile. 'To render common or unclean' (koinoo) occurs 14 times and clusters in the Mark and Matthew cleanness controversies and Peter's Acts 10 vision. The principle abrogates (formally cancels) intrinsic ritual defilement of ingested matter, which removes one possible class of objection to tobacco but does not address health damage or dependency, which are different categories entirely.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Rom.14.2	Gen.1.29	tsk	1
Rom.14.12	Eccl.11.9	tsk	1
Rom.14.10	Rom.2.16	tsk	1
Rom.14.13	1Cor.8.9	openbible	1
Rom.14.14	Mark.7.19	openbible	1
1Cor.6.19	1Cor.3.16	openbible	1

Complicating texts

1Cor.6.12 · addressed

'All things are lawful for me, but not all things are helpful' (panta moi exestin all ou panta sympherei), 'all things are lawful for me, but I will not be dominated by anything' (panta moi exestin all ouk ego exousiasthesomai hypo tinos), that is, all things are lawful but not all are beneficial and I will not be brought under the power of anything. The paired contrast structure 'is lawful' (exestin) yet 'is beneficial' (sympherei), plus the future passive 'I will be mastered' (exousiasthesomai), qualifies any bare liberty claim with a benefit and non-domination test. Across the canon 'is lawful' (exestin) appears 31 times and 'is beneficial' (sympherei) 17, and they co-occur at 1 Corinthians 6:12 and 10:23, so the qualification is internal to the very chapters the proposition cites. The proposition already concedes health-stewardship cautions, so the text limits but does not contradict the liberty framing.

1Cor.10.23 · addressed

'All things are lawful but not all things are helpful' (panta exestin all ou panta sympherei), 'all things are lawful but not all things build up' (panta exestin all ou panta oikodomei), that is, all things are lawful but not all are beneficial, not all build up. The slogan from 6:12 is reissued in 10:23 with the added test of 'builds up' (oikodomei), edification of others, before Paul tells the Corinthians 'whether you eat or drink, or whatever you do, do all to the glory of God' (eite oun esthiete eite pinete eite ti poieite, panta eis doxan theou poieite) in 10:31. This subordinates indifferent acts to a Godward end and a community-building test. It does not classify tobacco by lexeme (the actual dictionary word) but raises the bar for any practice that cannot pass both tests.

1Cor.6.19 · unaddressed

The 'sanctuary' (naos) and bought-with-a-price language can be read as a stewardship boundary strong enough to count health-damaging or dependency-forming use as failure of trust, or as a general dedication that leaves specific bodily choices to conscience. The bundle gives no lexical datum (no word-level fact) that selects between these readings for a substance the text never names. The tension remains open and drives the disputed verdict and the low confidence.

Rom.14.21 · addressed

'It is good not to eat meat or drink wine or do anything that causes your brother to stumble' (kalon to me phagein krea mede piein oion mede en ho ho adelphos sou proskoptei), that is, good not to eat meat or drink wine or anything by which your brother stumbles. The construction 'it is good not to' (kalon to me) with infinitive (a verb in its base 'to do' form) states a positive evaluation of voluntary abstention rather than a prohibition of the act, which is the exact lexical shape the liberty-with-stewardship reading predicts. The clause bounds liberty by neighbor effect, which the proposition's cautions clause already accommodates.

Concordance traversed

G4983, G3485, G1392, G0059, G1832, G4851, G2068, G2919, G4355, G1848, G5426, G2168, G4348, G4625, G2840, G2316

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

Romans 14 and 1 Corinthians 6 to 10 fall outside the CBGM (Coherence-Based Genealogical Method, a modern textual-criticism tool) 3 John sample scope. The cited verses carry minor scribal variation noted by the editorial sigla (the small marks editors use to flag variants) in the bundle, such as placement of 'but the' (ho de) in Romans 14:3 and a 'Lord' (kyriou) or 'God' (theou) reading at Romans 14:10 and 14:12, but none of these touch the lexemes (the actual dictionary words) that carry the disputable-matter, stewardship, or stumbling-block force, so the verdict is stable across the plausible readings.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. new_covenant_theology, covenant_theology, ascetic-holiness

analogia scripturae invoked

liberty-and-conscience reading of Romans 14 with Mark 7:19 and Rom 14:14: for · Reads tobacco as a paradigm disputable matter governed by Romans 14:3 to 14:6 where opposite practices are both validated 'before God' (coram Deo) with thanksgiving, reinforced by 'nothing is unclean in itself' (ouden koinon di heautou) in 14:14 and the declaration in Mark that abrogates (formally cancels) intrinsic defilement of ingested matter. Use is not sin per se (in itself) and judgment of the abstaining or using brother is forbidden. Stumbling-block restraint of 14:13 and 14:21 is internal to the liberty teaching rather than a refutation of it.

stewardship-of-the-body reading of 1 Cor 6 and 10: disputed · Reads 'sanctuary' (naos) in 6:19, the 'you were bought' (egorasthete) and 'glorify' (doxasate) pair in 6:20, the 'is lawful' (exestin) and 'is beneficial' (sympherei) and 'I will be mastered' (exousiasthesomai) clauses of 6:12, and the 'do all to the glory of God' (panta eis doxan theou poieite) rule of 10:31 as raising a real question whether a known health-damaging or dependency-forming practice

can be conducted to God's glory. The body as consecrated sanctuary rather than neutral instrument shifts the burden of proof onto any specific use that demonstrably degrades it.

ascetic-holiness reading taking 1 Cor 6 as a quasi-prohibition: against · On its strongest lexical form, this lens reads 'I will be mastered' (exousiasthesomai) as a categorical refusal of habitual dependency, 'sanctuary' (naos) as ruling out willing pollution of consecrated space, and the 'stumbling block' (proskomma) and 'snare' (skandalon) density of Romans 14 as making any conspicuous self-harming practice a positive offense against weaker conscience. The lens is lexically possible because the words it leans on are real and emphatic, but it must derive a verdict on a substance the canon never names from category arguments, which is the same constraint the liberty reading faces.

The two New Testament loci (text locations) are harmonized by 'the analogy of Scripture' (analogia scripturae, the principle that Scripture interprets Scripture) rather than set against each other. Romans 14 establishes the disputable-matter category, 1 Corinthians 6 and 10 bound it with stewardship and edification tests, and Mark 7:19 with Romans 14:14 removes intrinsic ritual defilement from ingested matter. The proposition sits where these intersect, and the absence of any anchor lexeme (a key dictionary word) for the substance is what prevents a single-direction verdict.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Whether tobacco use belongs to the category of practices that Scripture leaves to individual conscience subject to a duty of bodily stewardship and neighbor love, or whether it is intrinsically prohibited.

The original stem preloads the conclusion in two ways. The phrase 'matter of Christian liberty' already assigns the practice to the 'indifferent matters' (adiaphora, things neither commanded nor forbidden) category that is the question at issue, and 'not sin per se' (not sin in itself) asserts the negative verdict the analysis is meant to test. The verdict was derived against the neutralized form, which states the open question without presupposing the liberty classification. Because the substance is absent from the lexicon (the catalog of biblical words), even the neutral form cannot be resolved from word study alone, and that absence is the lexical root-cause of the disputed verdict.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.14.3
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.14.13
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4983
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3485
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1832
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4851
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4348
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2840
syntax	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.6.19
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Rom.14.12
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Rom.14.14

License audit

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Source	License	Redistribute
MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes

STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes
TSK	public_domain	yes
OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes

Flags

lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow · complicating-unresolved